economic survival, as they attempted to hold on to the dwindling support of their sole remaining royal patrons.

The preceding treatment of early buildings in the ambit of the Firuzkuh Shansabanis has aimed to highlight the manifold significances of architectural patronage in building empire, as much for elites emerging from nomadism and/or seasonal transhumance as for all other power-brokers. Indeed, the Shansabani elites' limited conversance with literary cultures beyond recognizable Qur'anic phrases or verses, and other common Arabic doxologies, also resulted in an epigraphic corpus devoid of the types of poetic, political, and other inscriptions in Persian that graced (for example) Ghaznavid complexes.[90] Nevertheless, by commissioning a monumental public structure such as the Shah-i Mashhad complex, leaving at least an acknowledged presence at Chisht, and erecting the Jam-Firuzkuh *minar*, the Firuzkuh Shansabanis were simultaneously extending patronage to the various *madhhab*s and spiritual movements vying for greater politico-economic prominence throughout Khurasan. Perhaps most importantly, in the process of patronizing "civic" or otherwise landmark architectural sites – emphatically *not* palaces – the ambitious Firuzkuh Shansabanis were literally and figuratively building their own bases of power. During the second half of the twelfth century, their projects daringly began to encroach on the well-plied networks of trade and communication radiating from the cosmopolitan emporia of Herat and Nishapur (cf. esp. Volume II).

Patrons and Patronage

The foregoing analysis of the more firmly attributable built traces of the Firuzkuh Shansabanis began with some seminal questions regarding architectural patronage. We interrogated what monumental building ultimately *meant*, what it accomplished especially for elites emerging from transhumant/nomadic lifestyles and economies and going on to create an empire. It is equally important to examine the overall relationship between patron and outcome, that is, historically, the degree to which the preferences of, and input by, the one(s) "paying the bills" impacted the architectural result. There is surely no unitary answer to the last question; investigators across disciplines would be hard-pressed to craft a convincing, universally applicable characterization of the relationship between *all* patrons and their projects, even within a specific region and timespan.

These considerations are all the more relevant for the Shansabanis, for at least two reasons. First, we have seen throughout Chapter 3, and this one that the plural "Shansabanis" actually encompassed essentially independent lineages, each responding to and shaping disparate cultural geographies that ranged from Bamiyan through Ghur, and eventually